Questions to Ask Mom's Doctor, Her Pharmacist and Local Care Providers While You're Planning Ahead

Fourteen questions, sorted by who can answer them, with room to write what they say.

Mom has a routine appointment coming up, and she's said you can come along. Bring the questions written down, ask them as they are, and write the answer under each one. They don't all have to be asked in one visit.

This guide doesn't answer the questions and doesn't say which matters most. That depends on Mom, and the people below are the ones who know her health or their own services. Ask her first which of these she's comfortable with you raising.

Mom's doctor

The doctor she sees for routine care. Go with her, and let her answer first.

1. Here are the changes we've noticed during the past year. Which of them would you like to look at?

2. How can we tell when Mom might need more help? What would you want us to watch for?

3. Is there anything about her memory, her balance or how she gets around that you'd want us to write down between visits?

4. Which changes would you want to hear about before her next routine appointment, and how do we reach you?

5. Given her health today, which kinds of care would be worth our learning about now?

Her pharmacist

1. Can you go over her full list with us: prescriptions, over-the-counter items, vitamins and supplements?

2. What do you offer that helps a person keep track of her medications?

Local care providers

A home care agency, an adult day program, an assisted living or memory care community, or a skilled nursing facility. You are collecting information, not choosing.

1. What kinds of help do you provide, and what don't you provide?

2. How do you find out whether you can meet a particular person's needs?

3. How do your charges work, and what is and isn't included?

4. Which ways of paying do you accept?

Your Medicaid planner

Someone who looks at the whole picture with your family: how Mom is doing, what she wants, and how care is paid for.

1. Here is our picture of how Mom is doing today and what she has told us she wants. What else would you want to know?

2. Which questions about care options and what care costs should we take to her care providers?

3. Which changes would call for a fresh look at this picture?

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer these questions or tell you which one matters most. Nothing here is medical, legal, financial or tax advice. If something seems to need attention sooner than the next routine visit, call her doctor's office and say so.

Ready for the next step?

You have your questions, and soon some answers. The care interview walks you through Mom's situation area by area, so the answers have somewhere to go, and turns them into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›